

Enemy mines and booby traps caused tens of thousands of American casualties, second only to small arms fire. The psychological consequences of these weapons were perhaps worse, because soldiers in the bush understood that any step could be their last. On any patrol, the danger was particularly acute for the “point man”—the first man in a column of troops—whose every sense strained to catch sight, sound, or scent of the enemy. To ensure the point man was mentally and physically fresh, point duty was normally rotated.

While all Americans who served in Vietnam suffered homesickness, loneliness, and resentment that life at home was moving on without them, combat troops also had the responsibility of taking lives, and to hesitate to do so could prove fatal. Some struggled to reconcile the killing with religious prohibitions on violence, but a few reveled in it; most, however, recognized it as an operational necessity. They had a job to do, and they owed it to each other to do it well. The loss and maiming of colleagues during combat also took a mental toll.

The vast majority of combat troops approached the challenges they faced stoically and with a high degree of professionalism, even though most of them were draftees or draft-motivated volunteers who never wanted to be soldiers.



Chest deep

Private First Class Fred Greenleaf, with other soldiers and members of an Army Ranger Group, waded through an irrigation canal on the way to a Viet Cong-controlled village during Operation Rang Dong in 1967.